

Perspective Glasses Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 25-30 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	25-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	perspective-glasses

Big idea: Perspective can limit and enrich knowledge.

Overview

Students see that the same event can be known differently by different knowers.

Student Prompt

Inspect Perspective Glasses Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Perspective Glasses Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Four role cards: scientist, artist, historian, and advertiser looking at one object. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Perspective Glasses Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A classroom photo interpreted through safety, beauty, efficiency, and fairness lenses. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Perspective Glasses Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A perspective switch where students must defend a reading they did not choose. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Perspective can limit and enrich knowledge.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Perspective Glasses Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Perspective Glasses Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Does perspective limit knowledge or enrich it?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how perspective can limit and enrich knowledge.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: Four role cards: scientist, artist, historian, and advertiser looking at one object.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Four role cards: scientist, artist, historian, and advertiser looking at one object.
- A classroom photo interpreted through safety, beauty, efficiency, and fairness lenses.
- A perspective switch where students must defend a reading they did not choose.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Assign groups different perspectives: student, teacher, parent, university admissions officer, AI company, another student.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Each group lists what they know, what they care about and what evidence they would request.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Groups present their interpretation.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	The class separates factual disagreement from value disagreement.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat perception or memory as a recording device.
- Students may assume confidence is evidence rather than a feeling about evidence.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Separates perception, memory, belief, confidence, and justification.
- Uses the activity result to make a cautious claim about knowers.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Change Blindness Starter
- Confidence Calibration Test
- Personal Knowledge Map